

THE MODERN JIVE SKILLS TOOLKIT

84 skills · Detailed reference · mjhub.dance

TIMING & RHYTHM

6 skills

On-beat movement

Making controlled contact with the floor as the body moves in time with the music's beat.

Up/downbeat movement

Using the lighter lift of the upbeat and the stronger, grounded feel of the downbeat — the 1, 3, 5, and 7 of the musical count — to structure the movement of the dance. Movement and momentum commence on the upbeat and resolve on the downbeat, the signature rhythm of Modern Jive.

Timing ownership

Staying on time with the music as best you can, even when your partner's timing varies. Quickly and smoothly returns to the musical beat if going off time.

Syncopation

Using off-beat movements deliberately, then returning cleanly to standard time.

Speed changes

Adjusting the speed of your movement and dynamics, not just your footwork, to match a slower or faster feel in the music, then returning cleanly to standard time.

Patient following

Ensuring new movements are not rushed or made ahead of the leader, filling the full duration of a beat with movement.

FOLLOWER

TECHNIQUE

19 skills

Concertina action

Timing in-and-out movements with your partner to match the downbeat and upbeat.

Posture

Holding an upright, balanced body line.

Intentional step size

Adjusting step size for song tempo, feel of music and partner, typically smaller rather than larger steps.

Minimal arm extension

Keeping elbow low and relatively close to the body in concertina movements, with the forearm as horizontal to the floor as possible.

Balance & centring

Centring weight over your own axis and base, with awareness of where your centre is, so you're never accidentally off-balance.

Rolling footwork

Using foot articulation to roll feet through the floor rather than marching, bouncing, or stomping.

Relaxed, supportive frame

Holding a frame that's firm enough to lead or follow but not tense or rigid.

Sending/receiving weight

Sending weight smoothly off one foot, and sending your centre of gravity fully over your other (receiving) foot as you receive it.

Grounding

Engaging your core and posterior chain, and the use of turn out in the feet, to commit weight down into the floor, creating a stable connection with the ground beneath you.

Minimum force

Using the minimum necessary force to move yourself and/or your partner.

Body flight

Managing your body's inertia smoothly through space when accelerating, decelerating, or maintaining constant motion.

Spin technique

Spotting and controlling the body through a turn, maintaining a vertical axis and avoiding falling into the spin.

Line of dance

Maintaining a line of dance suitable to the context of the surroundings, or intentionally breaking from it to create contrast or impact.

Turn height adjustment

Adjusting hand and arm height during assisted turns to suit both partners' comfort, height, and turning style.

Body articulation

Moving your body through space with control and fluidity, rather than moving rigidly or all at once.

Body leading

Leading with body weight and rotation, not by pulling or pushing with the arm. Influencing rather than physically moving your partner into position, often through subtle suggestion rather than firm direction.

LEADER

Active/passive leading

Choosing whether to continuously guide a movement (active) or give an initial impulse and allow your partner's own momentum or interpretation to complete it (passive).

LEADER

Direction before rotation

Initiate a direction for the follower before initiating rotational motion.

LEADER

Responsive following

Reacting to the leader's communication with minimal delay, typically from your center, without forcing or resisting.

FOLLOWER

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CONNECTION & TEAMWORK

15 skills

Resistance in partnership

Matching your partner's resistance in compression and opposition, giving genuine weight they can lead or follow off rather than just touching hands.

Non-verbal check-ins

Offering small smiles, nods, or glances that reassure your partner mid-dance.

Elastic connection

Creating stretch in the connection and letting it recoil, rather than just pushing or pulling.

Baton passing & sharing

Giving, taking, or sharing the lead in a moment, whether that means initiating an idea, building on your partner's, or creating something together.

Call and response

Replicating or building on your partner's movements when musical cues provide the opportunity to do so.

Partner ability adjustment

Adjusting to partner's ability and style quickly.

Partner trust

Establishing and embracing trust in your partner.

Counterbalance

Using opposing weight with your partner to create shapes neither of you could hold alone.

Clear communication

Giving directional information that's readable and easy for your partner to interpret, whether through subtle physical or visual cues, while minimizing unnecessary physical or visual noise that could create confusion.

Preparation

Creating the physical and timing conditions that allow your partner to execute a movement successfully.

Visual connection

Staying visually engaged with your partner and/or an audience if appropriate. Not staring at your feet.

Graceful recovery

Re-establishing frame, rapport, and connection smoothly after a miscommunication or mistake, without a lasting impact on the dance.

Conversational dynamic

Treating leading and following as a two-way exchange, not a one-way instruction.

Synchronicity

Transferring weight in sync with your partner — with the leader slightly ahead to initiate movements on time — and matching your partner's rhythmic choices, such as accents and pulses, so you're moving as one. Used once both of you are confidently holding your own timing.

Owning your rhythm

Filling in your own footwork and timing opportunistically.

FOLLOWER

MUSICALITY & INTERPRETATION

15 skills

Mood expression

Dancing in a way that reflects the emotional tone of the song, not just its beat.

Contrast in movement

Using contrast in the size and/or tempo of your movements to match changes in the music.

Improvising surprises

Adjusting on the fly when the music does something unexpected.

Lyrical interpretation

Incorporating movements relevant to the sound, melody, or literal meaning of the lyrics.

Legato movement

Incorporating smooth, flowing movements.

Energy matching

Adjusting how big or small your movements are to match the song's energy.

Using musical structure

Hearing and interpreting music in groups such as 8 and 32 beats, and recognising song sections such as the intro, verse, chorus, and bridge, and dancing in a way that reflects them.

Genre adaptation

Adapting the moves, movements, and/or timing of your dance to different music genres, and incorporating influence from other dance styles, while remaining authentically Modern Jive.

Groove

Moving your body continuously in a way that embodies the tempo and feeling of the music, beyond just landing on the beat — can include using staccato and legato movements to shape that feel.

Narrative arc

Building a sense of story or journey with your partner across the song.

Accenting hits

Building up to and emphasising a strong musical accent through your movements and/or moves.

Musical pauses

Using stillness deliberately at a musical pause, rather than filling every beat with movement.

Tension & release

Reflecting the building and release of tension in the song, including building up toward key musical moments.

Staccato movement

Incorporating sharp, distinct movements.

Variety of moves

Leading a variety of moves and patterns throughout the dance.

LEADER

STYLE & SPIRIT

13 skills

Personal styling

Adding your own individual flavour or flourishes to the dance, without being selfish or compromising the leader/follower dynamic. Includes adapting to different music genres and borrowing from other dance styles while remaining authentically Modern Jive.

Facial expression

Letting your face reflect enjoyment and engagement, not a blank or serious look.

Individuality

Expressing your own personality within the partnership.

Hairology

Using the hair to add to the feel and visual appeal of the dance.

Level variation

Varying the vertical height of your movement, such as going low or standing tall, for visual interest and musical expression.

Aesthetic lines

Creating aesthetically pleasing lines through your own body shape, and together with your partner, including using your arms and legs as a natural extension of the body to add to the feel and shape of the dance.

Confidence & presence

Carrying yourself with self-assurance, even through a mistake.

Enjoying the moment

Enjoying the dance and the partnership, rather than just executing moves.

Entertainment value

Being entertaining to your partner or an audience, such as through your energy, charisma, appropriate humour, eye contact, adopting a persona or character, and/or creating special moments.

Body isolations

Moving one or multiple parts of your body (such as ribs, hips, or shoulders) independently of the rest, often used in a coordinated way such as a body roll or rhythmic walk.

Playfulness

Bringing a fun energy to the dance rather than over-seriousness.

Space creation

Creating physical or musical space for your partner to add their own styling.

Wardrobe choice

Choosing an outfit appropriate to the surroundings, that plays to your strengths, while allowing you to feel comfortable in yourself.

FLOOR CRAFT & SAFETY

8 skills

Surroundings awareness

Keeping a general sense of where other couples are around you as you dance.

Respecting space

Not invading another couple's dancing area, even when the floor is crowded.

Hazard steering

Guiding your partner actively around obstacles or other couples on the floor.

Space-scaled moves

Shrinking or growing your moves to fit the amount of floor space available.

Checking comfort

Checking and accommodating for what your partner is or isn't comfortable doing.

Alert trust

Trusting the direction of the leader while maintaining spatial awareness.

FOLLOWER

Collision recovery

Adjusting calmly and quickly if you or your partner nearly collide with another couple, and offering a quick apology.

Respecting physical boundaries

Respecting your partner's personal space and physical boundaries, and never touching inappropriately.

REPERTOIRE

8 skills

Turns

Safely using one or multiple turns, such as two-footed or one-footed turns, in time to the music, using good judgement based on your partner's comfort and ability. **Leaders:** Avoiding leading excessive consecutive turns, which can leave a follower dizzy if not broken up with non-turning movement.

Ducks

Safely leading or following duck turns (ducking under a raised arm) in time to the music, using good judgement based on your partner's comfort and ability. **Leaders:** Avoiding leading excessive consecutive ducks, which can leave a follower dizzy if not broken up with other movement.

Baby aerals

Safely lifting the majority of a partner's weight below a certain height threshold — often the waist, chest, or shoulders depending on the school or competition — in a way that matches the music, and returning them safely and smoothly to the floor, only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness.

Leans

Leader: Using core strength and connection points to safely support partner's weight off the vertical via a lean against the body, and only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness. **Follower:** Using core strength and connection points to lean weight against partner's body, waiting for a clear lead rather than anticipating the movement, and only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness.

Rides

Safely using partner's momentum and/or balance to support complementary motion, in a way that matches the music, and only with appropriate training, safety awareness, and good judgement based on your partner's comfort and ability.

Aerials

Using core strength and strong connection points to safely lift and return a partner from/to the floor, in a way that matches the music, and only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness.

Dips

Leader: Using core strength and connection points to safely support partner's weight off the vertical using body part(s) such as your hand, arm or leg, and only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness. **Follower:** Using core strength and supporting as much of own weight as possible during a dip, waiting for a clear lead rather than anticipating the movement, and only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness.

Floorials

Safely incorporating movements where a body part other than the feet touch the floor, in a way that matches the music, and only with appropriate training, consent, and safety awareness.